

Thus started a tug of war between Microsoft, which viewed the free software community as nothing more than thieves who were out to steal its technology, and the free software community that saw Microsoft as a corporate monopoly out to kill innovation with patents and copyrights.

By the late 1990s, the free software community had grown significantly, and the ‘Free Software Movement’ founded by Richard Stallman had started discussing appropriate terminology to describe the paradigm. The term ‘free software’ was seen as a label with political motivations put on the movement by Microsoft and other tech giants to insinuate that the community only produced unauthorised software or pirated forms of technology. With the birth of Linux and its subsequent popularity, the free software community had evolved into something much greater than a network of tech hobbyists making DIY home projects.

In 1998, at a meeting at Palo Alto, California, the term ‘open source’ was proposed by a committee of the members of the Free Software Movement. Linus Torvalds and Richard Stallman gave their support to the proposal, and the term was quickly adopted across the community.

Eric S. Raymond, one of the members of the committee that helped coin the term open source, started the Open Source Initiative later that year. However, the open source community never truly got rid of the ‘free’ label, as even today any software developed under the open source paradigm is labelled as FOSS (Free and Open Source Software).

Meanwhile, Microsoft grew stronger in its stance against open source. Leaked internal memos from the company at the time, which later came to be known as the ‘Halloween Papers’, showed the company’s attempts to find strategies to tackle the surge of open source development.

The brunt of the ire was on Linux, which was being seen as a popular alternative to proprietary operating systems. While Microsoft led the race (and continues to do so till today) in the personal computer market, Linux quickly gained popularity as an operating system for developing and distributing all forms of technology — from simple machinery to advanced space equipment.

The winds had begun to shift in the developer community and open source was quickly becoming the norm. This became all the more apparent when Netscape released its source code under the Netscape public licence. Microsoft could feel the tables turn.

Microsoft and open source: From 2000 to 2013

Bill Gates’ stance remained unchanged despite the growing popularity of open source. His successor CEO at Microsoft, Steve Ballmer, also remained a staunch critic. On one occasion, Ballmer compared the developers of the Linux kernel to communists. In many interviews during the course of this period, Bill Gates continued to argue that the open source paradigm stunts the development of innovative software.

Despite its strong vocal stance against open source, Microsoft had started to experiment with open source development. In 2004, Microsoft released Windows Installer XML under an open source licence. This was the first software by Microsoft to be made available under a public licence. In the same year, Microsoft participated at LinuxTag, the biggest open source software exposition in Europe, held in Germany.

In 2005, Microsoft released the F# programming language under Apache 2.0 License. In 2006, it launched CodePlex, a platform for sharing open source software targeting Microsoft products.

With the growing popularity of Linux distributions and the demand for

interoperability between Windows and Linux, Microsoft partnered with Novell to create interoperability between Windows and SUSE, a distribution of Linux. This way Microsoft could provide interoperability for its users and make sure to keep its competitors in check.

In 2007, Microsoft hired Tom Hanrahan, the former director of engineering at the Linux Foundation as the director of Linux interoperability. In the same year, the Open Source Initiative approved two public licences designed by Microsoft — the Microsoft Public License (MS-PL) and Microsoft Reciprocal License (MS-RL).

In 2008, Microsoft officially joined the Apache Software Foundation and co-founded the Open Web Foundation in collaboration with Google, Facebook, IBM and others. Microsoft also started distributing the open source JavaScript library, JQuery, along with the Visual Studio IDE.

In 2009, Microsoft started contributing to the Linux kernel and released the source code of .NET Micro Framework to the developer community under the Apache 2.0 License.

The first tools for Python deployment on Visual Studio were released in 2011 and in the same year, Microsoft ported Node.js to Windows. Microsoft was also the fifth largest contributor to the Linux kernel for the year 2011, contributing nearly 4 per cent of the changes made.

Microsoft officially partnered with LinuxTag for the latter’s 2011 event and sponsored their 2012 event too. In 2012, Microsoft started running Linux virtual machines on its Azure cloud platform which quickly rose to popularity. The same year, Git support was also launched for CodePlex. The Typescript programming language became the first open source project by Microsoft to be uploaded on GitHub. In 2013, Microsoft added Git support to the Visual Studio IDE.